THE CURLY CHEF

KESAR ROYALE

Eggless brown-butter, saffron & cashew praline cookies

YIELD	PORTION	REST	OVEN
12 cookies	58–60 g	12–18 hours	175°C conventional

Flavour profile: Deeply nutty brown butter, fragrant saffron and green cardamom, roasted cashews, crisp cashew-praline shards and pockets of white couverture. The ideal cookie has a tender centre and delicately golden edges.

Completely eggless. Use thick, strained full-fat Greek yoghurt and good-quality white couverture. Weigh ingredients accurately for consistent results.

1. Ingredients

A. Cookie dough

Ingredient	Quantity	Notes
Unsalted butter	150 g (to yield 120 g)	Brown; cool and weigh after cooking.
Light brown sugar	75 g	
Caster sugar	35 g	
Thick Greek yoghurt	35 g	Full-fat, strained; room temperature.
Vanilla bean paste	4 g	
Saffron infusion	5 g	0.12 g saffron steeped in 5 g warm milk.
Plain flour	185 g	
Roasted cashew meal	35 g	Finely ground and cooled.
Skimmed milk powder	15 g	
Baking powder	2 g	
Baking soda	1 g	
Fine sea salt	2 g	
Ground green cardamom	0.6 g	
Roasted cashews	65 g	Chopped into 4–6 mm pieces.
White couverture	50 g	Fold 35–40 g into dough; reserve remainder for topping.
Cashew praline	90–100 g	Fully cooled, finely chopped; adjust to taste.

B. Cashew praline

Ingredient	Quantity
Roasted cashews	60 g

Ingredient	Quantity
Caster sugar	45 g
Water	12 g
Fine sea salt	0.3 g

Cashew allocation

Roast approximately 160 g cashews in total. After cooling, allocate 35 g for cashew meal, 60 g for praline and 65 g for the cookie dough. Keep the portions separate.

2. Detailed method

1. Roast the cashews. Heat the oven to 150°C. Spread approximately 160 g cashews in one layer and roast for 8–12 minutes, stirring once, until fragrant and lightly golden. Cool completely. Weigh out the three portions above. Never grind warm nuts; they can release oil.

2. Make the praline. Put 45 g sugar and 12 g water in a clean saucepan. Heat over medium heat without stirring. Swirl gently as the syrup turns amber. Add 60 g roasted cashews and 0.3 g salt; stir to coat. Spread immediately on baking parchment. Cool until completely hard, then break and chop into 3–5 mm pieces. Store airtight and dry.

3. Infuse the saffron. Lightly crush 0.12 g saffron. Add 5 g warm milk and leave for at least 10 minutes, until distinctly golden and aromatic.

4. Brown the butter. Cook 150 g butter in a light-coloured saucepan over medium-low heat. Stir and scrape the base as it melts and foams. When the milk solids turn amber and smell nutty, remove from the heat immediately. Transfer all solids and butter to a heatproof bowl. Cool until soft, opaque and pliable, not liquid. Weigh exactly 120 g. If short, top up with softened unsalted butter.

5. Make cashew meal. Pulse 35 g cooled roasted cashews in short bursts until fine. Stop before the nuts turn oily or become a paste. Sieve if necessary.

6. Mix butter and sugars. Work 120 g soft brown butter with 75 g light brown sugar and 35 g caster sugar using a sturdy spatula. Mix into a cohesive, soft, grainy caramel-brown paste. Do not whip heavily.

7. Add wet ingredients. Mix in 35 g Greek yoghurt, 4 g vanilla and the saffron infusion. Scrape the bowl and mix until fully incorporated, with no white yoghurt streaks.

8. Combine dry ingredients. Whisk 185 g flour, 35 g cashew meal, 15 g milk powder, 2 g baking powder, 1 g baking soda, 2 g salt and 0.6 g cardamom. Fold into the wet mixture in two additions. Stop as soon as no dry flour remains; do not knead.

9. Add inclusions. Fold in 65 g chopped cashews, 35–40 g chopped white couverture and approximately 90–100 g finely chopped praline. Reserve a little chocolate and praline for topping if desired. Distribute evenly without overworking.

10. Portion and rest. Divide into 12 portions of approximately 58–60 g. Shape into slightly tall mounds, not flat discs. Place on a lined tray, cover airtight and refrigerate for 12–18 hours.

11. Bake. Preheat a conventional oven to 175°C (165°C fan). Place chilled portions on a cool, parchment-lined tray, leaving at least 7 cm between them. Bake for approximately 11–14 minutes, until the edges are set and golden while the centres remain slightly soft. Use colour and structure as the final guide.

12. Finish and cool. If desired, press reserved chocolate and tiny praline fragments onto the cookies immediately after baking. Rest on the tray for 10–12 minutes, then transfer carefully to a wire rack. The centres finish setting as they cool.

3. Professional checkpoints

Stage	Correct result / control
Brown butter	Amber milk solids and toasted-hazelnut aroma; black solids taste burnt.
Butter temperature	Soft and opaque, not hot or runny. Hot butter can make dough greasy and encourage spread.
Dough texture	Soft, cohesive and scoopable. Fold only until combined.
Praline	Completely cool and crisp before chopping; warm praline can melt into the dough.
Chilling	Cover airtight to prevent drying and odour absorption. Bake directly from chilled.
Baking	Golden edges and a slightly under-set centre. Do not wait for the centres to become firm in the oven.

4. Storage and service

Cool completely before storing in an airtight container in a cool, dry place. For best eating quality, serve within 2–3 days. For longer storage, freeze the shaped, unbaked portions in a sealed container; bake from frozen at the same temperature, allowing extra time and checking the edges and centre. Do not stack warm cookies. For commercial sale, validate shelf life with suitable packaging trials and, where appropriate, water-activity or microbiological testing.

5. Serving suggestion

Serve at room temperature or warm briefly. A tiny pinch of flaky sea salt on the warm surface can sharpen the sweetness. Pair with espresso, lightly brewed black tea or saffron-infused milk.